



WINNING THAT GOVERNMENT CONTRACTING AWARD · SESSION 4 OF 4

Basics of Proposal Writing

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Scan now: your worksheet

BEFORE WE START

Scan your worksheet

- 1** **Point your phone camera at the code.** Or click the link in the Zoom chat.
- 2** **Fill in page 1 now.** Name, email, business, where you are today.
- 3** **Keep the tab open.** Today you write two real sentences in it.

Link is in the Zoom chat

Don't hit Submit until the last slide. When you do, the slides and a proposal-writing checklist land in your inbox.



TODAY

What we're covering

01 The blank page problem

03 Features and benefits

05 Customer focus and the evaluator's job

02 Compliant, correct, compelling

04 Themes, discriminators, ghosting

06 Writing mechanics and graphics

PART 1

The blank page problem

Three wrong starts, one right one

Last proposal

Written for a different customer and different criteria.
Evaluators can tell.

Marketing copy

"World-class solutions provider" scores zero points.

Technical manual

Everything you know, none of it tied to how they score.

The compliance matrix

Start here: the requirement, where it goes, how it's scored.

Start from the matrix row, not a blank page.

PART 2

**Compliant, correct,
compelling**



Compliant → correct → compelling

BAR 1

Compliant

You followed every instruction and answered every requirement. Miss it and you can be eliminated before anyone reads your best work.

BAR 2

Correct

Your solution works, your staffing makes sense, your numbers add up. This gets you to "Acceptable."

BAR 3

Compelling

Clear themes, quantified benefits, customer focus. This is what moves you from "Acceptable" to "Outstanding."

On an LPTA buy like Friday's, bars 1 and 2 are the whole game.

PART 3

Features and benefits

The "so what?" test

Benefit: what the customer gets	
A supervisor assigned to every region	One accountable contact, so deficiencies get fixed the same day
Backup porters on call	Callouts never leave an office uncleaned
Monthly QC inspections with written records	The contracting officer's representative sees problems before recruiters do

After every sentence, ask: so what?

Weak, better, best

Weak: feature only	"Our company has provided janitorial services for 10 years."
Better: + benefit	"Our 10 years of janitorial experience lets us close deficiencies within 24 hours, so offices stay ready for applicants."
Best: + proof + customer	"Across 3 comparable federal contracts, our supervisors closed 98% of deficiencies within 24 hours, keeping USACE's 29 Maryland recruiting offices ready for every applicant visit."

Example written for class. Formula: feature → quantified benefit → proof → the customer by name.

WORKSHEET CHECKPOINT · SECTION A

Write one "so what" sentence

Section A of the worksheet: one feature of your business, its benefit to a government customer, and the proof. Then combine them into one sentence.

Link is in the Zoom chat



Lost the tab? Scan again.

PART 4

Themes, discriminators, ghosting

What you want them to remember

- The conclusion you want the evaluator to reach
- A quantified feature plus a customer benefit
- The customer first, in the RFP's own words
- Two or three sentences, 40 words max
- 3 or 4 per proposal, woven through every section

3 or 4. Not 10.

Evaluators read 15 or 20 proposals. They remember three things.

Good, better, best themes

Good: compliant	"Our quality control program meets all PWS requirements."
Better: quantified	"Our quality control program inspects every site monthly and closes deficiencies within 24 hours."
Best: customer first	"Keeping USACE's recruiting offices applicant-ready every day, our quality control program inspects every site monthly and closes deficiencies within 24 hours."

Example written for class.

What makes you different

COUNTS

- Near-identical past performance
- Key people the customer already trusts
- Local presence when competitors are remote
- A certification competitors lack
- A method with documented results

DOESN'T COUNT

- "We have the best people"
- "We're committed to quality"
- Technology claims with no specifics
- Anything every bidder could say

Ghosting, done right

WHAT YOU KNOW

**They're
remote**

A likely rival's supervisor is hours away

so

WHAT YOU WRITE

We're local

"Our supervisors live within 30 minutes of every Maryland site."

Never name them. Never knock them.

PART 5

Customer focus

The 2:1 rule

2:1

the customer's name to yours

About you	"Acme Cleaning has 15 years of experience maintaining federal offices."
About them	"USACE's recruiting offices will benefit from 15 years of maintaining comparable federal offices."

Count both names in your draft. If yours wins, flip it.

Make their job easy

DO

- Answer every requirement, in the RFP's order
- Use their words: if they say "plan," say plan
- Clear headings that match the requirement
- Tie it back: "In response to PWS 1.2 ..."

DON'T

- Rewrite requirements in your own words
- Reorganize their structure
- Leave leaps in logic
- Bury your best point mid-paragraph

WORKSHEET CHECKPOINT · SECTION B

Write one win theme

Section B: one win theme for a government customer you want, 40 words or fewer, customer first. Then count: whose name shows up more, yours or theirs?

Link is in the Zoom chat



Lost the tab? Scan again.

PART 6

Writing mechanics and graphics

Write so they can score it

- Short, declarative sentences
- Lead each paragraph with the key point
- Numbers beat adjectives
- Back every claim with evidence
- Active voice: "Our team will ..."
- Paragraphs of 4 or 5 sentences

	Replace with
"World-class"	A number
"We believe / strive"	"Our team will"
"We understand"	Show it in the approach

Graphics that score

1 Process diagram Your method, step by step	2 Org chart Real names, real reporting lines	3 Schedule Their milestones, your dates
4 Comparison table Claims backed by data	5 Site map For us: 125 offices by region	6 Caption with a theme Every figure says why it matters

Original, not clip art. One good graphic can replace two pages.

WATCH FOR THESE

Common proposal mistakes

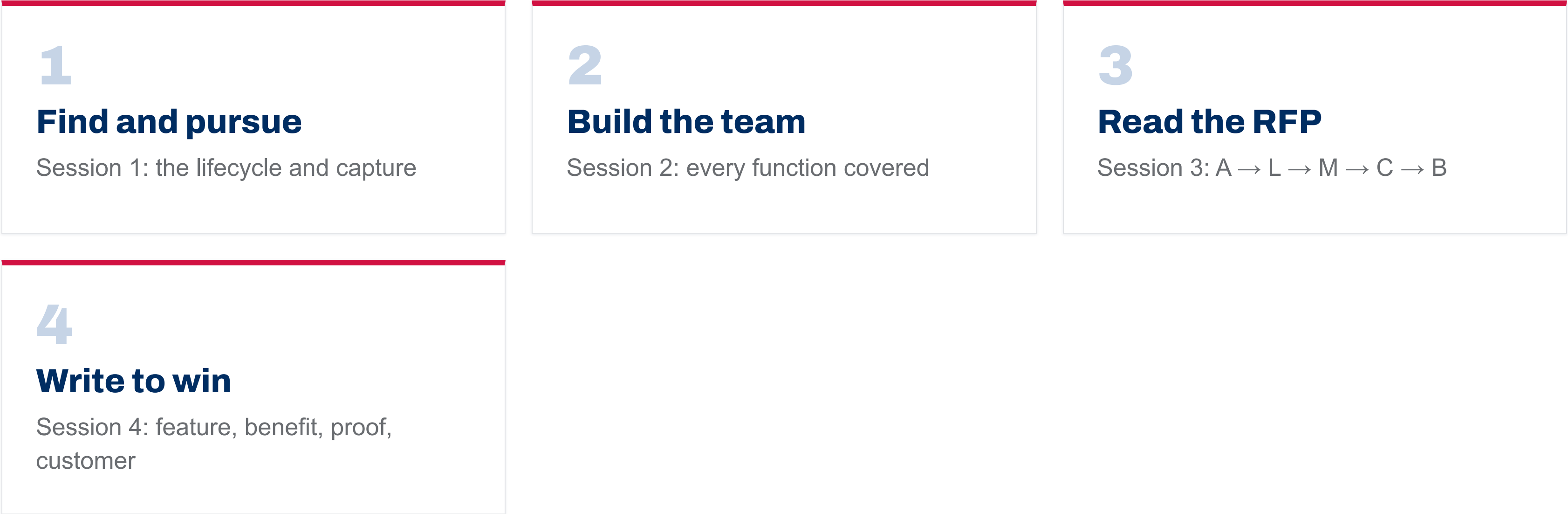
LOSES

- Missing a requirement
- All about you, not them
- Telling, not showing how
- Claims with no evidence

BLENDS IN

- No differentiation
- Walls of text, no graphics
- Marketing language
- Themes invented at the deadline

How it all connects



Capture feeds themes. Themes feed the matrix. The matrix drives the writing.

WHAT'S NEXT

Submit your worksheet

KEEP GOING

- Your capture template (Session 1) and compliance matrix (Sessions 2 and 3)
- *Persuasive Business Proposals*, Tom Sant
- acquisition.gov for the FAR, SAM.gov for opportunities
- Free 1:1 advising: capture, matrix, proposal reviews

WORKSHEET · SECTION C

Write your one step, then submit.

Your inbox gets: this deck with notes, a proposal-writing checklist, and every link from today.





Questions?

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